Class Act

By Michael Elkin

Setting: A school registration booth in a big city.
SARA is examining an unseen schedule posted on a wall, squinting and trying to make sense of it.

INTRODUCTION

Widowhood has become a new stage of an older woman's life. Almost half of women over age 65 are widows, according to the U.S. Census Bureau. In fact, it is widows who have set the example for how to remain active and stay involved–despite the crushing losses that come with old age. When you no longer can live as a wife, then you have to figure out who you are as a woman.

When your spouse dies, your world changes. You are in mourning—feeling grief and sorrow at the loss. You may feel numb, shocked, and fearful.. At some point, you may even feel angry at your spouse for leaving you. All these feelings are normal. There are no rules about how you should feel. There is no right or wrong way to mourn.

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SARA: Does that say two o'clock . . . excuse me, miss, does that say, Tuesday, two o'clock? (Ponders the response) You only have volleyball Tuesday at two? (Grimaces) No, it's not a problem It's just I get my nails done at one. You couldn't move the class to three? (Under her breath.) I don't know how you expect me to play volleyball with wet nails. (Turns head.) Badminton? Please, don't insult me. Badminton is not "in" this year. It's like playing mahjongg with old tiles You just don't do it. (Annoyed.) Audit? You want me to audit volleyball? I should sit and watch from the corner? Please, at my age I do enough sitting and watching. I don't have to go to school to be a bump on a log. I can do that on my own.

(Checks schedule) Wait . . . wait. What's this . . . (Points at schedule.) TM?

Vus a dus? TM? (She struggles with pronunciation) Transcendental meditation . . A course in relaxation. (Laughs) I can teach that. How to fall asleep in your chair when the news comes on. You call it TM? I call it Tom Brokaw . . . No . . . wait . . . I'll take it. (Looks at paper in her hand) It fills a hole for me. What hole? Wednesday. Good. Now I only have six more holes to fill. (Smiles.) You're laughing. See? That's because I'm funny, right? I wasn't always funny, you know. It's because I took a comedy course last year. You know what was a blast? Mr. Goldenberg, who sat next to me. He had gas problems that kept the whole class awake, you should pardon the expression. A real walking billboard for Gelusil. Oh, we had a special name for him too. Let's just say it began with "Old" and leave it at that. (Stares at wall).

I see the Yiddish class is filled up. (Laughs) Me? I know Yiddish like the back of my hand. (Looks at hand absentmindedly) Another liver spot. Overnight, they come out. You turn your back on them and they sneak up on you and say, "Peek-a-boo! You're old!" Just like that (Suddenly tired.) Oy! I've got to sit down. (Approaches stool) They don't make these for a 75-year-old tuchas. Thirty years ago, I could have done this.

Of course, thirty years ago I didn't wear orthopedic shoes, so I was closer to the ground. I've always said the day a woman starts wearing orthopedic shoes, she may as well announce to the world that it's all over. It's like getting up on a chair and yelling, "Hey I can't keep up anymore!" (Lifts up shoes to look at them) Did you ever see anything so mishuga? (Grimaces, then rubs her legs)

Old age? (Defiantly) No. That's not the problem today. It was the aerobics. I overdid it again. Me and Richard Simmons, we're an item. He kvetches, I

shvitz. (Leans over, conspiratorially) Ever hear him on Howard Stern? (Surprised) You don't know who Howard Stern is? It's the most disgusting show. I can't listen to it for more than an hour at a time. But at least I'm not afraid to listen, like some women I know. I'm hip. That's what my grandson tells me anyway. See this? (Points to her Grateful Dead T-Shirt).

He bought this for me, my grandson. He calls me Bobby. His father – my son, the attorney – said to him, "Stuart, how do you like your bubbie?" From then on, he calls me Bobby. (Shrugs shoulders) That was eight years ago. I told them to check his hearing, but my daughter-in-law – may she rest in peace – says no, that it's not my concern. So, what do I care? It's not my business. I wash my hands of it. I don't bring it up again with my son's wife – may she rest in peace . . . Hummm? No, she's still living, why do you ask? (Pause)

Anyway, my grandson, says to me, "Bobby, you're one happening mama. Real regular." Regular. (Pause. Holds up hand) Let's not even talk about that . . . But, you know, at least I've got a life. Not like those other yentas. That's what Jackie Mason would call them . . . yentas. Sure, I saw his show. Three times. With three different ORT groups. Yeah. And I belong to two Hadassah chapters. Why? For the trips. (Looks up).

Wait, I'll take that one. What's is called? "Jews You Didn't Think Were Jewish." Maybe they'll tell me something I don't know. Like? After all these years – I just learned Jerry Lewis was Jewish. Imagine, Jerry Lewis a Jew. (Frowns) Now exactly what I would call a victory for our side . . .

You know, I could teach a class myself, I've taken so many of them . . . What

could I teach? I could teach life. A class on how to mother – or how to smother – as my son used to say. He said I knew it better than anyone. Now, I can also teach how to play the bubba. Not that I get such a chance these days. Complaining? No, not me. My kids call like clockwork – if you got a clock that only works twice a year. No, it's fine. I have my life. Why do I need to mess up theirs?

(Straightens out hem of her shorts) I wouldn't have time for the kids even if they asked me . . . Besides, with all my courses, you think I could fit them in? I've taken crocheting, knitting, sewing . . . anything that ends in an "i-n-g" I take. My son says the only course left is kvetching and I already mastered that.

(Grimace) He's so funny. If they gave a degree just for me, he says it would be a masters of aggravation. An M.A. because it spells "Ma." He gets his sense of humor from me.

(Seriously) I'm funny when I have to be. Don't kid yourself, I know how to laught. But, somehow, it sounds different bounding off the walls in an efficiency apartment when the only noise you hear is yourself sneezing. Wait, I don't want you to think I don't have friends. Them I have plenty of. Mrs. Garfinkel, Mrs. Simon, Mrs. Robinson . . . No. Wait. (Pause) She's dead. Mrs. Robinson's dead. (Shakes head)

Such a lovely funeral. Everyone turned out. All of her friends from the club. Her husband? He passed on years ago. That's why she joined the club. Some of these women will do anything to forget, to have company. You make friends.

Friends who last your whole life – whatever's left of it. Like Mrs. Robinson and me. We were like this. (Entwines her fingers gingerly) Her first name? (Pause) I . . . never asked.

(Changing the subject). Say, is that mime you're offering again Friday afternoon? I took mime two years ago. Maybe three. Terrible. Terrible. They wouldn't let me talk. And what's a class without a little gossip? (Laughs) If I wanted someone who didn't talk, I'd dig up my dead husband. Fine conversations we used to have. Nu, Saul? How was work? "Nich te fellich," he'd say. Nu, Saul, what do you think of President Roosevelt's New Deal? "If it's good for the Jews, it's OK by me." Nu, Saul, what's the weather like tonight? "Dark." A scholar he wasn't

(Softens) No, no. But . . . But, he had his moments. Nu, Saul, what do you think of my new blue dress? (Stops, her eyes moist with memory) "It's beautiful, Sara. Just like you." (Grows somewhat softer, smiling a bit) He had a way, my Saul. . . So maybe he wasn't an Einstein. I never wanted a man with such messy hair anyway. Saul, let's go to the movies, I'd say. "OK, Sara, if that will make you happy." He did. He made me happy. He used to listen to me play the piano for hours and then he'd say, "Sara, please don't stop. I could listen to you forever." He would always tell me that I was the one in the family with the smarts, with the talent . . .He was the one with the heart . . . Did I tell you about our forth-fifth anniversary?

(Smiles; she seems to be growing younger) You know what he did? He took me dancing. Dancing. For the first time in our lives. Oh, he would step on my feet occasionally – oy, do you know what it's like to have someone give a shtup to a

hammer toe? I said, Saul, Saul, you're no Fred Astaire. And do you know what he said to me. He said, "Sara, that's OK, that's OK, because he only had Ginger Rogers and I have you. For that I'm luckier that Fred Astaire."

(Smiles). He said that. My Saulie. I guess that's why I loved him. He swept me off my feet. (listens intently) A prince? He was a king. But . . . (Whisking away imaginary lint from her shorts) . . . even kings don't live up to their word. And I never forgave him for that. (Listens.) Hmmm? No, I'd rather not get into it. (Taken aback) Cheat? Did Saul cheat? No. Of course not. He was a Jewish husband. No, my Saulie was a good man . . . How did he lie? (Long pause) What does it matter now?

(Long pause) He always told me that no matter what, "No matter what, Sara," he said, "I will always be there for you." My protector, that's what he called himself. My other lady friends, whose husbands fell asleep on the sofa watching reruns of Love Connection, they'd scream in their ears, trying to wake them up, "Be like Saul! Be like Saul!"

(Softly) Be like Saul.

(Pause) Our children, they grew up, they moved out. I never had time to be lonely because Saul was there for me. Always. "And I always will be," he told me. And then, just like that, he. . . wasn't. It wasn't the way we planned it. Death never is . . It . . . wasn't the way we planned it at all.

(Directly) Do you know what loneliness is? (Doubtful) Do you? (Shakes head) I'll tell you what it is. It's an old lady buying soup for one and freezing half of

it. It's making new lady friends so you have someplace to go on a Saturday. The couples you used to go out with Saturday night you don't see anymore. The ones who still have husbands don't want to be reminded what's in store for them. And those that don't . . . well . . they just stop calling. You stop calling. Everyone . . . stops. And suddenly, there's . . . nothing.

(Smiles) No, Saulie, as much as he loved me, he went back on his word. He left me. Alone And I'll never forgive him for that.

(Sarcastically) So, tell, me, on that big schedule of yours, with all these fancy courses, do you have anyone here who can teach me to deal with that? (Shakes her head, closing her eyes. Long pause. Slowly, sadly, she breaks away from her memories. Back to registrar, brushing back tears.)

So what's that, Thursday at three? Bungee jumping? (Pause) You jump from a WHAT? (Sighs) All right. Sign me up. Maybe I'll start out easy . . like getting up from a chair. Look, it couldn't be worse than physical therapy. I could use a good scream. What have I got to lose? (Looks at her own schedule.) Say, what do you have Monday at one? I've got some time to kill. Anything at two? No, how about three? (Nods head as she listens to registrar. Fade to black).

SOURCE INFORMATION

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